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Jerry Hey

Jerry Hey has been recognized six times with Grammy awards for his distinctive horn arrangements, frequently played by his own stellar group, the Jerry Hey Horns. His accomplishments include collaborations with Michael Jackson, Quincy Jones, Jay Graydon, and Al Jarreau.

Jerry was interviewed via Zoom on November 2, 2023 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive and I'm very appreciative of Jerry Hey joining me for a chat. Thank you.

JH: My pleasure.

MR: We have a couple of things in common, we were both born in 1950.

JH: Very true.

MR: It was a very good year.

JH: Yeah a very good year.

MR: When you think about growing up and listening to the radio, let's say by the time you were ten, twelve, do you recall the variety of music that you could absorb through AM radio back then?

JH: You know I didn't really listen to AM radio until probably I got to high school or maybe seventh or eighth grade you know and kind of The Beatles came in and you know, so that's kind of the first AM radio that I listened to. For the most part I was listening to records that my dad had bought.

MR: Which were what?

JH: Which were — he heard Clifford Brown live in 1954 I believe, in Chicago. I'm from Illinois. So he went into Chicago and heard Clifford Brown live and then bought his first, it was a ten inch record then, it came out a 33 RPM but it was ten inches, and it had the original version of "Cherokee" on it and "Easy Living" and some great stuff. So I had that, and then as Clifford Brown records came out my dad would buy those and some other Dixieland and some — my older brother had some records of Frank Rossolino. My brother was a trombone player. So there was a lot of listening to records more than listening to AM radio.

MR: Well that's fortunate for your musical tastes I think.

JH: Definitely.

MR: That's a pretty hip place to start.

JH: Yeah.

MR: Did the idea of becoming a trumpet player as a profession take a while to gel for you?

JH: Yes it did. I started very early, because as I said my older brother was a trombone player and in the Boy Scouts he played the bugle for whatever, the Taps and Reveille and all that stuff in the Boy Scouts, and brought it home one day and literally I just picked it up when I was kind of two and then at age three I got my first trumpet and played with my mom in church on Mother's Day. She played piano and I played then cornet. And so I started early and it was just something I always did. I didn't really know anything else. And you know, kept playing and I knew I was good. There was a really great band program in my home town run by this guy was basically the "Music Man" who had, there was 15,000 in this town and there were three bands in elementary school of 100. This guy, everyone in town played an instrument in grade school. So you know you have that many people and yes there are going to be a lot of really good people come out of that. So you know I kept playing and then eventually went to — I went to Interlochen Music Camp and got kind of a rude awakening there because you go from small town to, you know the best in the business there. And there were really a lot of great players there then, the years that I went. Phil Collins, who played first in Cleveland — I mean Cincinnati for a long time, a really great player; James Thompson who played in Detroit and Montreal I think, first trumpet with them; and five or six just world class guys there in high school. So you learn in a hurry how you fit.

MR: This would have happened to you but I had this fascination with big bands when I was about that age and I remember my parents taking me to see what would have been the Glenn Miller ghost orchestra if you want to use that term, and I played the saxophone and I was staring up at them saying, "That's what I really want to do." Did you have that kind of experience?

JH: We — my dad was a trombone player also, so he took me to hear Duke Ellington's band and then also took me to hear Stan Kenton, probably when I was sixteen or seventeen, both of those I guess. It wasn't really something I wanted to do was play in a big band. I liked it but it wasn't — I don't know it didn't stir me up to become a lead trumpet player or anything. But at the time I was taking trumpet lessons from a guy in Chicago Symphony so I was playing C trumpet in high school and kind of going in that direction of being a classical trumpet player and this guy was another like world class player who has become one of the foremost teachers in the U.S. for sure, Charlie Geyer. So you know I was kind of going in that direction through high school and he wanted me to go to Northwestern and study with Vincent Cichowicz who was playing second trumpet at the time in the Chicago Symphony and kind of do that route.

MR: Can you recall the first time that you understood that a song, a pop song, could have things added to it like horns, and the first time you ever got a pair of headphones on and had that experience? It's a tough one.

JH: Yeah. I don't remember the first time. I remember listening — when I started listening to AM radio in the late '60s I guess and there were some horns on things, you know The Beatles had a few horns, "Penny Lane" piccolo trumpet solo, and you know some of the other things. And then I guess Tower of Power sort of, and Chicago were kind of — Blood, Sweat & Tears, those kind of, the early versions of those were the first thing that I thought the horns sound really good and that's kind of interesting. I didn't really think much about it but okay, those guys are making a living playing trumpet. Okay.

MR: So what led you to believe that you could do that?

JH: When — so I went to Indiana University and studied with this William Adam trumpet teacher, just the greatest man I've ever met. And nothing to do with trumpet, just a brilliant man in all aspects of life. And he kind of made you play trumpet for any occasion. You know you have to learn how to play trumpet before you can play the piccolo solo on "Penny Lane" or before you can play a jazz solo, or before you can play lead you've got to be able to play the trumpet. You know it's about learning how to play the trumpet with him. So you were kind of set up as, I mean I went in as a classical trumpet player then heard these other guys playing, they would play in the orchestra, then they'd play first in the jazz bands at Indiana and they played jazz solos. And I go wow, those guys sound great and they're playing all styles. That's kind of what I want to do you know. So it was kind of an open door there for me to sort of spread my horizon from the legit world into whatever needs trumpet you know I'm kind of available for. So from then we moved — well I moved to Hawaii with one of the trumpet players that I met at Indiana and we started working over there and we formed a band over there and we're playing some top 40 tunes, Aretha Franklin and Tower of Power and those kind of things. And we've got to have horn parts so I transcribed the horn parts from the record. And that was kind of the beginning of, you know, my really listening to records and kind of trying to understand how the horns sounded on those records and how can we do that.

MR: A bit of delicious irony, I was in a band, many bands in the '70s and so forth, and that was my job as well, to listen to the records, and some of the horn parts that I was transcribing were written by you.

JH: Uh oh. Sorry.

MR: And you know it's the rests — it's the little sixteenth rests and so forth that are the hardest part.

JH: Yeah, yeah. You know I tried to make it a little tricky here and there and change up things here and there.

MR: It's almost like some of the things at the time you were doing were almost like writing out clavinet rhythms.

JH: Ah. Okay, I'll take that.

MR: Well I want to fast forward a little bit and really try to get into your thinking about when you got an assignment, a commission to write horn parts for a specific record, I think I read that first of all you have perfect pitch, is that correct?

JH: That is correct.

MR: So when you got a lead sheet — what did they give you? What did their producer give you and did you pay attention to it?

JH: Almost in every case all I got was, well back then a cassette. You know Quincy, David Foster or any of these things, they would send me a cassette of the song. That's it. If I ever got a lead sheet –- which was rare — I never looked at it because by the time the lead sheet — I did it in the beginning. Okay the guy sent me the lead sheet, usually just kind of rough chords, and I figured out that okay they repeated that and then they cut out these bars the next time and then they did this the next. You know it was like more work to look at their lead sheet than for me to take five minutes and write out a chart — a rough chart. And then with that, you know just kind of a pencil sketch of the tune, I would intensely listen to the song. I mean that's one of the better things that I think I do is listen to what they're giving me. Because that's going to stay. My horn parts, if I write some horn parts, they're not necessarily going to stay. But this is the rock for them, and I'm just going to be on top of that. So I have to know exactly what they like and what's there so I would know every keyboard voicing, all the guitar parts, the bass part, the drum fills. I would know all of that stuff and know where the vocal is that I shouldn't be. So that was kind of the modus of how I would write horn parts is start with all of that and listen to the song and then where does anything need to be.

MR: You know you pretty much answered a question of mine because I've done some of this and I wondered, you seem to be indicating that what was on the cassette was pretty much a finished rhythm track and it had a vocal on it, whether it was just a scratch vocal or something to show you where the singing was.

JH: Some of the Earth, Wind & Fire stuff the vocals were really sketchy so sometimes that's why some of the Earth, Wind & Fire horn parts are busy and kind of stepping on the vocals because there were no vocals there in some cases. Like "I Am" that had just kind of a really rough sketchy vocal so you know the track, which was basically David Foster, you just write whatever you want to write and Maurice will deal with it, you know take some horns out there or, you know. So —

MR: That's interesting now if you hear that and you might say to yourself well I wouldn't have written that there had I known.

JH: Yeah.

MR: I had a conversation with Tom "Bones" Malone recently and he said the idea is you don't conflict with the vocal because it's the most important thing. I'm just putting horns on

and make sure that they occur in their own space because I'm just the frosting on the cake.

JH: Absolutely. That is one hundred percent right. If you're playing when the vocal is playing the horns are not going to be heard because the vocal has to be heard.

MR: Did anybody ever have to tell you that or did you just know it?

JH: I guess it was a combination of listening to all of those top 40 records that I had to transcribe, and okay they're kind of — the horns have their own thing. You know there's a vocal and there's the horn parts you know so it kind of got that. Then I went in with Quincy doing something sometime you know and we just kind of talked about kind of how to approach it. And he said, "Yeah, you want to stay away from the vocal and you want to try to become part of the rhythm track." So obviously if the rhythm hits or whatever, or a melody line — instrumental melody line should be played you know you want to be kind of blend into the track like you were there from the beginning.

MR: Tom also said an interesting thing that you were basically the "King of the Unisons" which I thought was interesting.

JH: With horn parts when you have a lot of voicing and you have a lot of movement you can — I try to think of the horn parts as a melody. And when you have a lot of harmony and they're not going to be — it's not like a big band where the horns are going to be featured and you're going to hear all of the parts and everything, they're going to put the horns down a little bit and the melody part that I write for horns can get lost with all of the harmony. So if there's a line that you want to kind of emphasize and make sure everybody remembers, unison will come through better than a harmonized part.

MR: Who makes the call in a situation, a typical pop situation, that your horn parts are on the record or they end up on the cutting room floor?

JH: Always — well not always — but the producer is always has the last say. Sometimes, depending on how big the artist is, the artist can have a say in it, but you know it's generally the producer. Because I mean a lot of times the artist isn't even there when we do the horn parts.

MR: Have you ever had a producer who was inclined to say, "Guys that was perfect, let's do another one"?

JH: Oh all the time you know, yeah.

MR: What are they looking for?

JH: Well just — you know they're trying to get the magic somehow and they don't kind of always realize that, especially with brass instruments (trumpets included) it's not necessarily the more times you play it the better it's going to get. You know there's a point at which it starts going downhill kind of in a hurry, especially when it's really intense and involved and technically difficult. So fortunately I've had enough success

that I can say that's, you know, "It's never going to get any better than that." You know. "If you don't like the way that sounds I can change it but you know that was really good." So you know —

MR: You mentioned "Penny Lane" and I've read the anecdotes about how Paul McCartney heard this piccolo trumpet and then he sang what he wanted the piccolo trumpet to play and George Martin wrote it down. Have you ever had those situations in the studio where either the artist or the producer, "Hey Jerry, this would probably sound good" and they start vocalizing something at you.

JH: Yeah of course.

MR: Okay.

JH: Michael Jackson in a couple of instances. David Foster in a couple of instances, who also has perfect pitch and keyboard perfect pitch which is kind of crazy that he can listen to a song one time and play it back to you. Really amazing. And he's also wonderful in the studio, just a brilliant musical mind. And he would sing some things. This is back in the day, not everybody's got a demo and you kind of play what the demo is.

MR: So did you always have score paper with you?

JH: No. I only would carry around single line sheets and if, you know for the most part they're not singing a whole like section of stuff. You know? It's a phrase or two that they want to change. You know Maurice White, we'd go in and play my arrangement just rough the first time, I mean really mistakes and everything, just so he could kind of get the idea of where I was thinking. And then we'd sit down and he'd say, "Well how about if we try this" and he'd sing one phrase, you know, here instead of what I had. So that, but you know I'd just take a single line thing and whatever that was they'd sing it to me and I'd just write it down and then you know we'd go out and everybody's so fast in the studio I'd sing it to them or play it to them and everybody'd learn it and we'd record it and move on.

MR: Did the Jerry Hey Horns individuals get their parts beforehand?

JH: Only on a couple occasions did I send Gary Grant like any kind of real technical thing that I had written, just one or two bars, kind of the speed demon lick in Michael Jackson if you know that [scats] that crazy one. So I sent him that one just so we'd go in — saxophones, they can play anything you know. But you know that intense of a trumpet lick, so because I wrote it, I know it and I can play it. And if Gary's got a little head start on something then you know it's fewer takes for us to try to get it together because you've got four guys and there's a good chance that it's going to be — somebody's going to need to do another take and the fewer takes you can get on those really hard licks like that the better.

MR: Did you ever write something that you couldn't play?

JH: If I couldn't play it I wouldn't write it. But yeah, back in the day it was anything goes back then. You know Chuck Findley can play anything. You know Gary's amazing. And Bill Reichenbach on the trombone is also just a world class player. An amazing bass trombone player, trombone player, plays drums, great writer. And Larry Williams who also was in Seawind, and Dan Higgins who has been recently, who is just a brilliant musician. So you know you go in with those kind of guys like that, and now Wayne Bergeron added to the mix, you know it doesn't matter you could write anything and these guys are going to play it. It might take a couple of takes but it's going to get played.

MR: Do you get ideas in your head even when you're not really engaged in working? I guess I think I saw your dog come through the room. And when I take my dog for a walk if I'm working on an arrangement I get these things — you know I'm thinking more about how am I going to solve this little issue. I wonder if this happens to you?

JH: It kind of, in passing if I hear something — the other day I heard some vocal riff that was — wow that was really cool. How can we make that, how can I make that into a horn part that works you know. Stuff like that. But if I'm kind of working on a song and I used to like to listen to it, work on it, then, you know, take a walk and then without hearing the track kind of think okay here's sort of the — what about this — and then come back and kind of refine that.

MR: Do you employ the computer to write your horn parts now?

JH: About ten years ago a guy was working on — he wanted to do a Broadway show. And it was kind of on Studio 54 back in the sort of disco days kind of. And he had these songs and he wanted me to send him demos. And I said well I've got like 40 years of demos out there. You know what I do. If you want me to write horn parts you've heard kind of what I do. And he said, "Yeah but you know it's for this Broadway show and I want to make sure." Okay. So I had my son, who is a recording engineer — and a brilliant one at that — set me up in Logic. So I am just barely hanging on in Logic, but I can do a horn part in there and it sounds pretty good with some kind of cheesy horn samples when people need a demo. And if they don't need a demo then I'll do the horn parts in there and then I can print them out and they look pretty good coming out of there. So I mean it takes a minute to get from — to make it sound like I want it to sound. To make it how it should look is a total different animal. So like when you're doing like, say you're doing something like [scats] just that little turn like that, you know you have to kind of put a little —

MR: A diddley.

JH: Grace notes in the middle of it you know and then you look at it on the paper and it looks horrible.

MR: Right.

JH: So then you have to say okay so you just make that [scats] like that and then you put a turn on top of it in the written music. And if you want to do — oh what else is an issue like that — just a whole bunch of things like that — oh, to make it — if you're going to have, let's see, I don't know, but the notes aren't all beamed, the sixteenth notes separate — so I try to make it — I like to see every beat in a bar. So I make it so that you look at it you know where that note is going to come. You know a sixteenth note, whatever.

MR: I know what you mean. You want to be able to see the rests and the beats, and sometimes annoying things like you fix it and then you paste and copy it and it turns it back into what it thinks it should be.

JH: Right.

MR: That's not what I want.

JH: Yeah, no that's not right, yeah. But we have done sessions where the guy that wrote the horn part knows nothing about horn writing or really the theory of music. And so it would be like a quarter rest — no it would be like, it would be like a sixteenth rest and a sixteenth note, and then a quarter rest and then an eighth note. And then you're kind of going well wait a minute — you've got a sixteenth note rest, sixteenth note, and then you've got a quarter note rest and then you have an eighth note. Where does that eighth note come? You know. So stuff like that. And that can happen in the computer as well. So it takes, to make it sound like I want it to sound and then make it look like I want it to look is kind of two different jobs.

MR: I want you to see if you can name this lick.

JH: Uh oh.

MR: Yeah uh oh because I have to try to vocalize it, okay? [scats]

JH: So that's the "Rosanna" lick. And there is a note in there that most people don't know. It's [scats] all — there's a ghosted note in [scats] E ghosted in there [scats]. And that's why it sounds like that because you get that ghost and then you get the second part of the lick [scats]. Where if you just went [scats] that doesn't swing as well.

MR: I love that minutiae. Wow.

JH: Yeah so Dan Fornero was on a session the other day and he sang that [scats]. And I said, "You know there's this ghosted note." And he goes, "No!" I said, "Yeah."

MR: Well I used to have to play that on a synthesizer in a band and believe me, I didn't get the ghosted note.

JH: Yeah. Most people don't.

MR: Okay this one is more obscure. And I think it was a one-time artist for you so see if this rings a bell [scats].

JH: Nope. Nothing.

MR: I'll give you a hint, it was a British artist and his name was Nik Kershaw.

JH: Oh my God. Nik Kershaw to me was the hope for music, pop music, back in the day. Great tunes, great changes, wonderful melodies, interesting ideas. He was — it was incredible. We went to hear him live a couple of times and it was just like wow, I hope this is where music goes. And then he decided that "Wouldn't It Be Good" — his big hit song — was number one in the world except for here — and he decided he didn't want to be a pop star and kind of went underground and, you know.

MR: I couldn't agree more. His subject matter too, like there were no just like silly love songs, they were, the topics were very deep and the production, the whole shebang. I had a question about "Wouldn't It Be Good" there's that line there [scats]. Horns are playing that and is there a guitar playing with that?

JH: It was, so the original thing for Nik Kershaw was this producer said, "Why don't we have some horns on your record." And Nik Kershaw said, "Okay, let's try it." And the producer said, "What if we play the guitar solo?" So it was an original guitar solo so I took the guitar solo off and we played to the guitar solo. So, and then we also did, I said, you know they had these other songs [scats] that one you know so we did a couple of other songs, "Let the Drums Do the Talking." Brilliant. So that was just kind of a fluke that we played on that record because I knew the producer and the producer was going to be in L.A. He was also an English producer. So yeah, fortunate for us.

MR: When you read the minutiae about certain recordings I'm amazed that like Al Jarreau song "Breaking Away" I was just reading the minutiae about this and you know they had eight keyboard players and two guitars and two basses and horns and recorded in three or four different studios. I don't have a question there but it's amazing.

JH: Well different keyboard players on different songs so you know George Duke I'm sure played on some things and there's a guy who played in Al's band for a long time, Tom Canning, I'm sure he was playing. Probably David Foster. Who else? I'm not sure but you know, and then the guitar players would be Jay Graydon of course, who is the producer, an excellent guitar player. Steve Lukather played on some things. Probably maybe Larry Carlton or Greg Parker depending on what the song called for. But you know that's kind of standard. And Jay was the producer on that so you know he's kind of the overseer on everything. So it's going to all sound, because it's Jay, it's going to all sound like one unit.

MR: Yeah he had a great thing going on with those rhythm guitars and a certain kind of effect on them was really distinctive. I understand he liked to start his studio sessions like at midnight or something.

JH: Yeah. All the Jarreau horn parts were — I don't think we played a note before eleven maybe, and we would finish at six or seven in the morning. And on the Jarreau record we had already been booked during the day. You know the movie calls come out a month

ahead of time and so you know we're booked on other sessions from nine o'clock in the morning 'til six at night, you know playing on these, whatever TV movies and everything. And then we'd go to the Jarreau session and start at eleven and go 'til six or seven. Literally go home, take a shower, go to the nine o'clock or ten o'clock session. And we did that for a week for the Jarreau stuff. And on the fifth day, the Friday of that week, we had a nine o'clock call with Bill Conti for the 1984 Olympic music. And literally I'd had thirteen hours of sleep that week. And we go to this session, and we just got through with some brutal Jarreau stuff, you know one of those crazy ridiculously hard songs you know. And so you've got time to go home, take a shower, maybe get something to eat, nine o'clock session. And it's six trumpets. So I got there pretty early but not early enough to get the sixth trumpet book. I could only get the fourth trumpet book. Gary Grant beat me to the sixth trumpet book. Chuck Findley comes in at one minute to nine o'clock, hair wet, obviously he hadn't — he came directly from home, walks in and it's like [motions strings playing] and trumpet like solo over the strings, like bravura Olympic music trumpet solo. And then four pages of, you know, playing and then at the end it's the same thing, you know trumpet solo on strings. And he played the living hell out of it. And at that point I was lucky to even play. I was just shot. And so the rundown he played it perfectly. One take, great, and a viola player — "I think I have a wrong note." And yes there was a wrong note and we had to do it again, and Chuck played it better the next time. It was amazing. That was kind of like the Chuck Findley that you always have heard about, and his legacy. It was incredible because if I were in that situation I couldn't have played it.

MR: What a great story.

JH: It was one of those rare moments that you go okay, that is some sheer genius there, to be able to pull that off.

MR: Do you get envelopes in the mail on occasion with payments for things that you didn't expect?

JH: Yeah. Not a lot, but every once in a while. Dolly Parton's "9 to 5" is like $110 every couple of years I guess sort of. I played on "I Love L.A." with Randy Newman on the session that we did on that record. The bridge part of it, if you know that [scats] I said, they said, "Well what do you think about on this song?" And I said, "What about like a mariachi kind of thing, you know 'I Love L.A.' a mariachi." So I played that mariachi style, it kind of sounded like Herb Alpert in harmony parts you know. If they used it, it's really soft in the mix. But because I'm on the contract for that, when they use "I Love L.A." I get a re-use for that. What else? Oh I just got a Donna Summer re-use for, you know we did all those disco records that she did so I just got — and that was $80 or

something you know, like that. You know not a lot, but every once in a while something comes in.

MR: Well how do you price your own work? Your writing? And did it change over the years? I assume there's something with the union involved but then you eventually got beyond scale?

JH: You know when I first started out I didn't know anything. You know I'm a trumpet player. I don't know anything about arranging or arranging fees or how you charge for that. So the Michael Jackson "Off the Wall" stuff was $500 a chart, a tune. And you know okay that's a big success so okay raise it to $750 for the next kind of few years later, and you just kind of keep going. And then you hear guys that are charging $2500 for a chart, or $5,000 for a string chart, or $10,000 for a string — I've never been good at charging that. What I have to make sure is that the players get paid the right amount, and always double scale for the players. So if, especially with the budget these days, if the budget is low and I want to do it then I'll say, "Okay, you've got to pay these guys double scale and I'll take less for my arranging." Because I've got enough money. I don't really need that anymore. What difference does, you know if I get an extra $500, okay let's put that into the players to make sure the players are right. I've been having my son record the horns and it's just so much better than anybody but maybe Bruce Swedien. He's incredible. And you know the guys come in and every one to a man will say he's the best guy they've ever worked with. So working with him, you've got to pay him, you've got to pay the guys, if it comes out of my money I don't really care.

MR: I think there was a quote about Bruce that he said, "You can't just play softly with horns and then turn up the volume in the mix. You're not going to get anything."

JH: That is true. My statement on that is if you record a whisper and turn it up it's still a whisper, it's just a loud whisper. But if you record a yell and turn it down it's a yell. So taking that into how we play in the studio, it's pretty much full on all the time, to get the intensity. So if they turn the horns down, the intensity is still there.

MR: What makes Quincy Jones and David Foster and those tremendously successful producers, is there a similarity to their personalities or what made them so successful?

JH: Quincy is all about personality. You just, when you go into the studio with him you feel like the record would fail if you weren't in on this session. That's how he makes you feel, that you are a major part of this record-making process. And it's family, it's — you have a good time, you play great music, great engineer, great songs. He always works with the best artists. You know how can it not be great? That's Quincy's thing. I mean plus he picks songs you know. He always says the song comes first and yes it does. And anything else doesn't really matter if you've got a great song. David Foster is a brilliant musician, and like I said he can sit down and play anything right away. There was a Jarreau session

that he was playing on with Abraham Laboriel, bass; Lukather on guitar; I believe it was Steve Gadd on drums; and Jay Graydon, the producer/guitar player also, didn't like the bridge. So Jay said, "David, I don't really like the bridge you know, let's work on the bridge." So with they're all — including me — standing around the piano with David Foster and he goes [scats] how's that? And it was like, wow that was ridiculous. I mean this was just like cold doing this. And David goes, "Na, try something else." And David would go [scats] how's that? Totally different, equally as amazing. He did six or seven like that, just like eight-bar changes that were like guys would kill for any of those eight bars. Brilliant. And you know he just is, he's fantastic in the studio, just amazing, totally different approach personality wise than Quincy. Quincy makes you feel like, you know, the world revolves around you, and David it's all about David as the producer, you know regardless of who you are, even if you're Celine Dion or Whitney Houston or anything, it's David is in charge there. But you know some of the best things I've ever done are with David. You know it's always, the music is always great. Jay Graydon is another musician coming along with David, a little less hands-on than David. David is really hands-on. Maurice White, another brilliant producer with Earth, Wind & Fire — you know I learned some things with Maurice White that would — as I was saying before when we would do horn parts and he would sing a part. And I'd say, "Well you know Maurice that note's really, it's not really in the chord there that you're singing." He said, "I think it's going to work." And okay, you go out and you play it and you kind of force it into the, okay I get it, and then the more you listen to it's like yeah, I like it.

MR: And I wouldn't have thought of that, right.

JH: Yeah no, no way. So you know each producer that I've worked with has a little bit different approach as to how they get to finished product. You know George Duke, great guy, great player, you know just kind of knows the whole thing. He let me do some arranging for him.

MR: Do horn players still hate synthesizers?

JH: If, you know if they're abusing a synth, yeah of course. If they're you know taking the place of horn parts, which still is kind of difficult to do for trumpet. You can kind of get away with it on baritone saxophone and, you know, if you're going to have orchestra trombone pads you can kind of get away with that and French horns you can sort of get away with it. But you know synth is, if you use it like another musical instrument, you know, playing stuff that should be played by a synthesizer, then fine.

MR: Did you ever have a situation where you were adding a real trumpet to synthesizer trumpets to give it a little authenticity?

JH: Yeah. But if they were — if I was called they would probably have me writing a horn chart and playing with a section rather than do that. I have done a few of those playing

along, not necessarily playing along with synth trumpets but adding a trumpet to a synth part.

MR: Okay. Did you prefer the alto or the tenor in the Jerry Hey Horns for the most part?

JH: Never alto. Trumpet covers alto register and tenor has more body to the sound than alto does so I rarely write alto. I mean a couple times when it was — we did trumpet and alto just like that, like only a two horn thing where it would be kind of unison sort of in the treble staff. I would do that as a special kind of sound. But basically with a big section it's always tenor sax and bari.

MR: I see. Do you miss — are you still playing?

JH: No. I haven't been for I don't know, it's been ten years at least.

MR: Yeah. Do you miss it that much?

JH: Oh God, terribly. If I could play and not arrange I would take playing. But the playing of the arranging got us in as a section more than my playing did. So you know that's, the good news is that I can do this arranging and Quincy would call me to do the arranging, he wouldn't call me to do the playing, but because I was arranging I was playing. And then he found out that we could play but you know, so the arranging kind of got my foot more in the door than the playing I think. So it's, you know, it's kind of a curse of, it's part of the reason that I'm not playing anymore because I was so involved in the arranging that you have to worry about whether everybody's playing in tune, whether the cut-off was right, whether we're in time, whether the producer likes the horn parts, whether the engineer has a horrible sound on the trombone and we have to re-play the whole song, which we have done many times. You know there are so many other aspects to arranging for me that I want to make it sound like I know it should sound that it took away from my trumpet playing. So you know my focus was on the arranging and not on the playing. And it was always easy for me to go in originally — I could play anything. I mean literally play anything. So I could put my focus over there. But you know, the older you get, you know the harder trumpet gets, and then the focus still has to be over here to make sure that we're still sounding like we should sound, and the trumpet kind of started going downhill because of that. And then I had some health issues.

MR: Do you ever get over the moment of, I don't know if anxiety is the right word, but the first time you're reading down what you arranged and you're in the studio and the producer is there and you're waiting to hear the comment about your parts — or do they already know sort of what it's going to sound like?

JH: Well I don't know if they, you know, really Quincy may, Foster may, but you know a lot of the other people that are more producers and less musician, you know they're not necessarily, but the reason they hired me was because they liked what I've done in the past, so they know, I guess they're assuming that it's going to be what they're looking

for. You know sometimes they'll say, "You know I'm not really sure on that one." And okay, what can I do to make it better? But anything that I write, I don't care, it's their record if they don't like it I'll change it.

MR: Have you ever not gotten paid because they didn't like your writing?

JH: No. I've not gotten paid a couple of times because they were schmucks, but —

MR: Okay.

JH: But yeah, no that's kind of always upfront, this is how much it's going to cost you, you know studio engineer, horns and arranging, okay, great.

MR: I was going to ask your advice, if you have any, for people trying to get into the business. But I'm actually going to turn the question around a little bit. What kind of things could a young studio musician do to get them taken off the contractor's list?

JH: Oh to get them taken off? Well not show up on time. I mean there are a whole host of things you know? Not play well. Don't show up on time. Don't pay attention. Make a kind of a ruckus in the studio. You know just kind of not be a kind of a team player, which is what I really like because the guys I use are all, they're there for the music, they're good guys, they're friends. You know it becomes a team that way. So you know guys that are trying to make their own way and kind of stick out in a situation you know that can draw attention to them. What else? Wanting to charge too much money sometimes, if guys, you know I've had guys say, "Well I should be getting triple scale." Well you know what? Everybody else is getting double scale, you're getting double scale. You know that's just how it works. That's kind of what we go in. So there are — it's easy to — and of course guys talking down other players you know, that gets around quickly. You know don't like that. So there are quick ways you can get in a bad way with the contractor.

MR: I see. Did you ever see Quincy Jones get aggravated in the studio and what would cause that?

JH: I heard him talk one time about the music business and a couple of guys in the music business that were — he didn't like. Never anything in the studio — he likes, you know the studio is a rare kind of piece of Quincy's life that he likes to keep this family, everybody's loved who comes into this room. He likes to keep that like that so everybody wants to do their best for him, and knows that you're going in on a great artist and it's going to be a great song and great engineer and do your best. So he likes to keep that like that. One occasion that we played on a record and it wasn't — it was a big band situation and it wasn't all of the first-call guys in there. And it didn't sound like it should sound. And he called me up the next day and went off on this tune, just, I'd never heard him talk like that. It was just totally the opposite of what he was expecting to hear. So I said, "You know Quincy" we were going to go in the next day I think to record some other tunes,

and I said, "you know we'll just come in and we'll just replace it." And okay great, and that was the end of it. We went in the next day, with two trumpets, two trombones and two saxophones, and we re-did a big band. You know we overdubbed the big band and you know Quincy's happy. So that was really the only time that I really heard him rag about the music part of it.

MR: Was the original recording he didn't like, was it done live?

JH: No it was horn overdub. One, it wasn't Bruce. So that had a little bit to do, a lot to do with it. So you know we go in the next day and play it and it's Bruce and all the great guys and Quincy goes, "You guys just come in here and play the shit out of it." And I said, "Well that's what we're here for." So you know he was happy.

MR: Nice. Happy to hear that. I'll just wrap up with a question about what's coming up for you?

JH: I have a few things here and there, not a lot, and I'm okay with that. But you know I'll do kind of a project sort of, a month, and guys will call me up — we just finished a project from a guy from Germany who flew over to do the horns on three tunes. And we have a movie coming up that my son works for Harvey Mason Jr. if you know of Harvey Mason Sr., the drummer, his son is a big time producer and working on movies mostly now. My son works for him as his engineer and they're doing a movie that Pharrell has some songs in that we're going to play some horns on maybe next week. So you know a few things here and there, and I've got a couple kind of pending projects. But a project a month is kind of good.

MR: Is it tough for you over the years to, you want to send in the Jerry Hey Horns so does that mean that you have to get on the phone with all the members every time you get called for a recording session? To see that they could all make it?

JH: Well you know Gary Grant is not playing anymore so you know he was like a key member of the horn section. Bill Reichenbach has moved to near Asheville, North Carolina, and he's also another, was a key member. He comes back to play on movies now. He does all the John Williams' movies and plays on movies but he's not always here when I do a session. And Larry Williams, who is still playing saxophone but because of a lot of times it's baritone saxophone now and Dan Higgins plays everything amazingly well so he's kind of been the main guy. So I'll call — I mean I call the guys who I think are best for the job and Wayne Bergeron is kind of the guy now who can play anything. So he plays. Andy Martin plays trombone and Dan Higgins. The second trumpet chair is kind of rotating I guess. Dan Fornero's been playing a little bit and a couple of other guys play. Rashawn Ross, who plays with Dave Mathews — so you know it's still called the Jerry Hey Horns although it's not the same guys. But you know I'm doing the arranging and it still kind of sounds the same, not quite the same but close.

MR: I'm sure it's excellent, and it's a blessing to have that group of musicians who you'd have to go out of your way to get someone who wasn't cutting it.

JH: Yes. Yeah, no, the guys can play anything that you're going to write, and you know you just, for me I have to kind of, because I'm not playing and we're not playing with — so the guys in the original horn section, I went to Indiana with Larry Williams and Gary Grant, when we were living in Hawaii Gary Grant came over to Hawaii and we were together in Hawaii before we were in L.A. for four years we were in Hawaii before that. So we've known each other for 52 years, Gary. Larry Williams has been 55 years, and Bill Reichenbach I met on one session here when we were first in town in 1976. So you know it's hard to get that team who played together for 40 years, and now you've got new guys coming in who don't have that team playing together thing that I kind of have to, okay this is how I want that phrased, and this is how I really want that to sound. And it's not necessarily like they would play it if I wasn't there. So I'm still trying to put my influence on the tunes.

MR: Okay. Well I really appreciate your time today and I should mention that I see that you're a Lakers fan.

JH: Oh God, yeah.

MR: Yeah? Well I have to tell you that I'm a Celtics fan so.

JH: Oh no.

MR: So maybe we'll meet in the playoffs, ey?

JH: Oh well I don't know, LeBron's putting in too many minutes already, yeah. Greatest rivalry back with Magic and Bird.

MR: Yes indeed.

JH: Oh it was just spectacular. I would watch the game live and record it, and watch it the next day again and oh, just the best of times.

MR: Indeed.

JH: Yeah.

MR: Every once in a while I'll get on YouTube or whatever and, you know, watch Larry's greatest ten whatever.

JH: I've watched that recently. It's just incredible. But then somebody had the other day they had Durant versus Bird in the stats and all that. Kevin Durant would kill Larry Bird in stats.

MR: Yes.

JH: I don't know whether I would take Kevin Durant over Larry Bird but it's kind of frightening. But I always say if I had to start a team of all the players the Lakers have had, Magic Johnson would be my first choice of anybody in the NBA to start a team. Because he made everybody better.

MR: All right.

JH: As Larry Bird did.

MR: Well maybe someday we can meet in a bar over — and talk about Magic and Bird and continue that.

JH: Yeah well I'm up for that, a glass of wine.

MR: Thanks for your time today, Jerry.

JH: Sure. Nice. Bye.